Acidic extraction of histone proteins

Histones are highly basic proteins that can be selectively extracted from cells, nuclei, or chromatin using dilute acids—a method first described by Kossel in 1884. This modernized protocol, adapted from Holt et al. (2021), enables efficient recovery of histones from small or precious samples.

The protocol uses acid extraction followed by trichloroacetic acid (TCA) precipitation to isolate total histones while minimizing loss of many post-translational modifications. It is particularly suited for downstream applications including Western blotting, immunoprecipitation of free histones, and LC-MS/MS proteomics. Start from a nuclei pellet SOP 0001 or from the insoluble pellet of a nuclear extraction SOP 0025. The extract holds dissociated histones without their DNA or partners; nucleosome-level studies should use the native chromatin protocol instead SOP 0047. Formaldehyde-crosslinked material extracts poorly unless the crosslinks are reversed first.

Risk assessment

- Work with highly flammable liquids
- Work with concentrated acids

▷ Handle acids and flammable liquids in a certified chemical fume hood

▷ Wear gloves, safety glasses, lab coat

☐ Collect acetone as ORGANIC SOLVENT WASTE



Reviewed: Oct 27, 2026

Procedures

›› *Acid extraction*

- ☐ 0.2 M HCl (R0025 for 1 M)
- ☐ 1 g/mL TCA
- ☐ 99.9% Acetone, with HCl
- ☐ 100% Acetone
- ☐ Glass Pasteur pipette

(1.) Start with a nuclei pellet or a nuclear fraction isolated from approximately 1.0×10^6–1.0×10^7 cells. Approximate the packed cell volume; this is 1 vol.

> ***Hint:*** Continuous cell lines such as HeLa, U2OS, or 293T yield sufficient material from 1×10^6 cells, while 1.0×10^7 cells may be required for finite cell strains or primary cells.

(2.) Gently vortex the pellet from the preceding nuclear isolation or extraction procedure.

(3.) *Critical:* In a dropwise manner, add 5 vol (10 vol if starting with fewer than 1×10^6 cells) of 0.2 M hydrochloric acid to the pellet at 4 °C. Gently pipette up and down to disperse the pellet.

> ***Critical:*** Add slowly to avoid rapid precipitation. If working with small volumes, pipette gently rather than dropwise.

(4.) Incubate on ice for 5 min. 5 min

> ***Note:*** Precipitation occurs rapidly; there is no benefit in increasing the duration of this step. However, extended incubation up to several hours will neither affect results, making this a reasonable break point.

(5.) Centrifuge at 15 000 × *g* for 5 min at 4 °C. Transfer the supernatant to a clean tube.

> ***This is why:*** The supernatant contains histones and basic proteins. The pellet contains non-histone nuclear proteins.

(6.) To the supernatant, add 0.25 vol of 1 g/mL trichloroacetic acid. Vortex vigorously to precipitate histones.

> ***Critical:*** Mix immediately and completely to avoid incomplete precipitation.

(7.) Precipitate on ice for 5 min. 5 min

(8.) Collect the histone pellet at 15 000 × *g* for 5 min at 4 °C. Discard supernatant.

> ***Note:*** TCA precipitation preserves most PTMs.

(9.) Carefully add 100 µL cold (−20 °C) 99.9% acetone with HCl to the pellet. Do not disturb the pellet!

This is why: Hydrochloric acid displaces residual TCA, which can interfere with downstream MS applications.

Quality assurance: Since acetone can degrade some plastics, perform washes quickly in compatible tubes.

(10.) Centrifuge at 15 000 × *g* for 2 min at 4 °C. Remove acetone using a glass pipette.

Quality assurance: Do not scrape the walls. Leave residual solvent rather than risk losing pellet material. A small amount of acetone will evaporate quickly.

(11.) Repeat acetone wash using 100 µL pure acetone (without HCl).

(12.) Air dry the pellet at room temperature.

Critical: Avoid overdrying. Desiccated pellets may be difficult to redissolve.

Storage of isolated histones

(1.) Store the histone pellet at room temperature for a few days at most. For anything longer, keep at −80 °C.

Hint: The crude pellet is not a long-term storage form. Histones keep for years only once they have been fractionated by HPLC and dried: purified aliquots are stable in sealed tubes at room temperature, as freeze-dried pellets or in low salt buffer. Avoid repeated freeze-thaw cycles once reconstituted.

⊞ Optional: *Fractionation by reversed-phase HPLC*

- ☐ HPLC solvent A ⟋ R0097
- ☐ HPLC solvent B ⟋ R0098

(1.) Fractionate the histones by HPLC for long-term storage or mass spectrometry analysis.

(2.) Resuspend the dried histone pellet in 85 µL HPLC solvent A.

Hint: Any routine reversed-phase solvent pair of water and acetonitrile with trifluoroacetic acid serves; take the pellet up in solvent A alone.

This is why: Some pellets may not fully dissolve, particularly if total cell lysates were used instead of purified nuclei. Histones are highly soluble, so incomplete dissolution often reflects contamination with insoluble debris. Clarify by centrifugation.

(3.) Inject the sample into a reverse-phase HPLC system equipped with a C18 or C3 column.

Hint: Use columns with large pore size (300 Å) and small particle size (3–5 µm) to preserve histone integrity. For example, Grace™ Vydac® 218TP C18, 2.1 mm × 150 mm, 300 Å, 3 µm.

(4.) Separate histones using a linear gradient of HPLC solvent B starting at 20–30% B and running over 30–60 min.

Critical: The linker histone H1 elutes first, ahead of the core histones, and H3 last: the order is H1, then H2B, then H2A and H4, then H3, but it is not fixed, and lowering the column temperature can shift it. Start collecting at the beginning of the gradient to keep H1, or only once the core histones begin if H1 is not wanted. Modified histones and histone variants elute across the whole window of about 25–60% B depending on sequence and modification, so a fraction is assigned by gel or mass spectrometry rather than by retention time alone.

Hint: H2A and H4 often overlap. Where they must be separated, pool those fractions and reinject them on a shallower ramp through the same window rather than lengthening the whole gradient.

Analyses

○ Analyze extracts (or HPLC fractions) by SDS-PAGE and Western blot or prepare for downstream use such as immunoprecipitation or mass spectrometry.

> ***Critical:*** Ensure buffer exchange or neutralization of residual acid before enzymatic assays or antibody-based detection.

Materials

Acid extraction

- ☐ **0.2 M Hydrochloric acid (HCl)** (◇ R0025 for 1 M)
- ☐ **Trichloroacetic acid (TCA)**, 1 g/mL
  CAS 76-03-9
- ☐ **Acetone**, 99.9%, with HCl
- ☐ **Acetone**, 100%
  CAS 67-64-1
- ☐ **Glass Pasteur pipette**

Fractionation by reversed-phase HPLC

- ☐ **HPLC solvent A** ◇ R0097
- ☐ **HPLC solvent B** ◇ R0098

Recipes

Acetone, with HCl, 99.9%

Amount	Ingredient		Stock	Final
10 µL	HCl, 37% Skin corrosion (H314)	[7647-01-0]	12.0 M	0.1%
To 10 mL	Acetone, reagent-grade			

99.9% Acetone

with HCl



DANGER

Flammable liquid; Serious eye irritation; Drowsiness or dizziness

- ☐ Collect as ORGANIC SOLVENT WASTE
- ☐ Keep away from oxidizers

Date: Sign:

List of references

M.V. Holt, T. Wang, and N.L. Young, *Curr. Protocol.* **1**(2), e26 (2021).

A. Kossel, *Hoppe-Seyler's Z. Physiol. Chem.* **8**(6), 511–515 (1884).

Change log

2023-10-26 **Benjamin C. Buchmuller** Adaptation as SOP.

2026-10-27 **Benjamin C. Buchmuller** Storage of the crude pellet is cut from one week to a few days, and the years-long figure moved to HPLC-purified histones. Elution window corrected from 15 to 45 percent B to about 25 to 60 percent B. TCA stock stated as 1 g/mL. Dropped the one-hour processing window and the claim that the elution order is fixed. All of it follows Holt et al., 2021 (Curr Protoc 1:e32), which the procedure follows throughout.

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